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(54) **METADATA DOCUMENT UPDATES FOR APPLICATION DEVELOPMENT PLATFORM**

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(57) **ABSTRACT**

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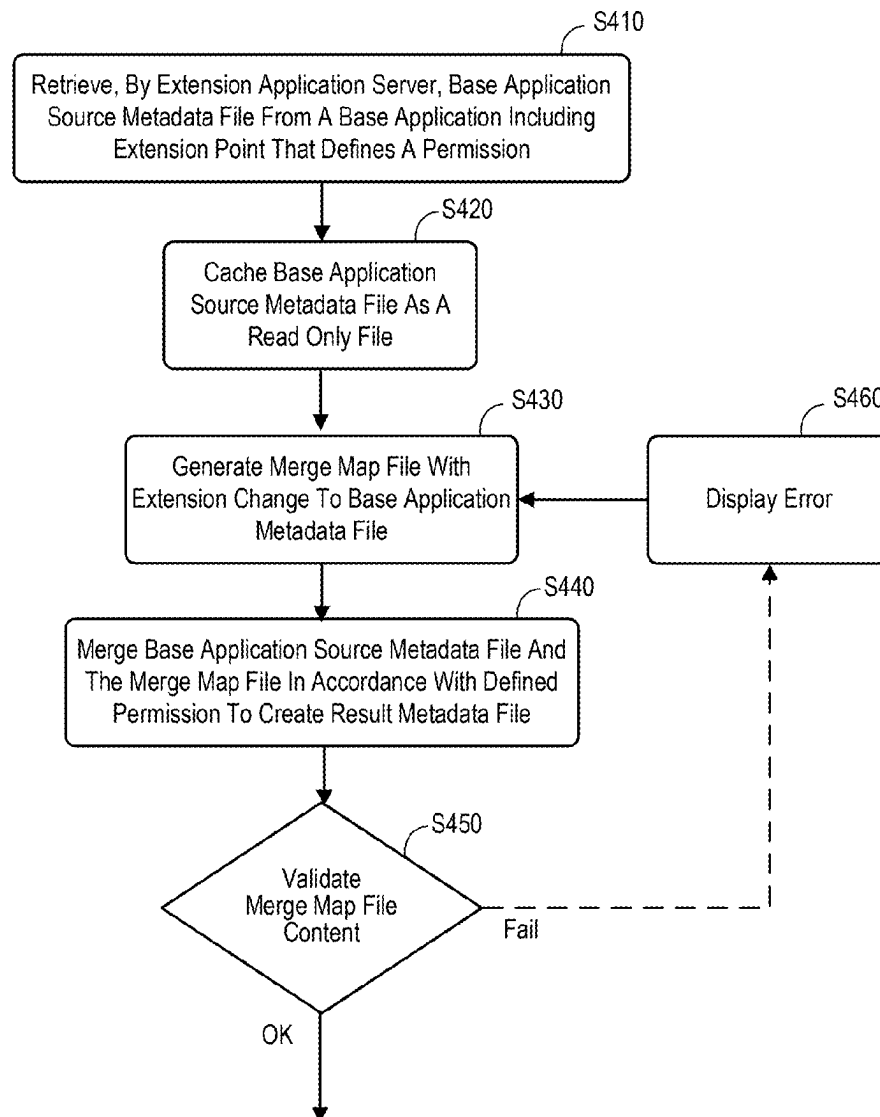
A base application data store may contain a base application source metadata file with at least one extension point that defines a permission associated with the extension point in connection with a base application. An extension application server, coupled to the base application data store, retrieves the base application source metadata file and caches the base application source metadata file as a read only file. The extension application server then generates a merge map file with an extension change to the base application metadata file. The base application source metadata file and the merge map file may be, for example, merged in accordance with the defined permission to create a result metadata file for the base application. In some embodiments, the extension application server subscribes to application updates for the base application, and the extension change is reported and validated in accordance with the permission associated with extension point.

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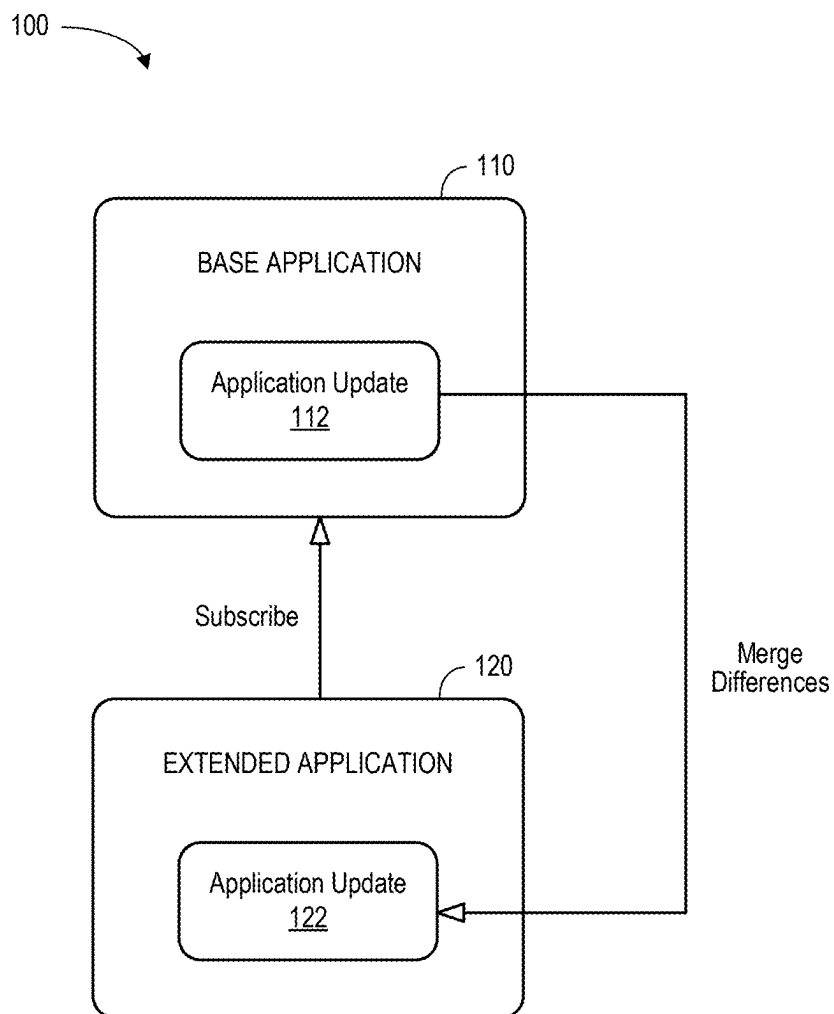


FIG. 1

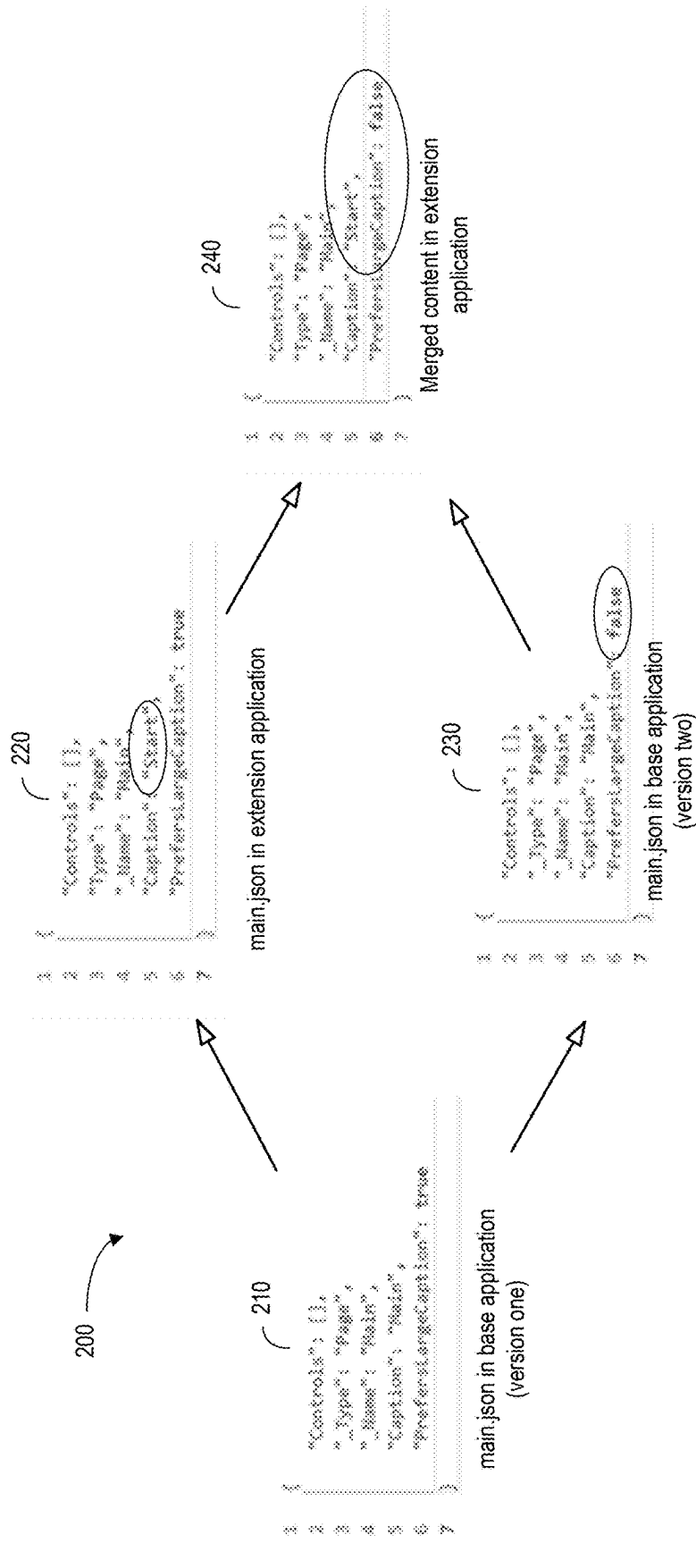


FIG. 2

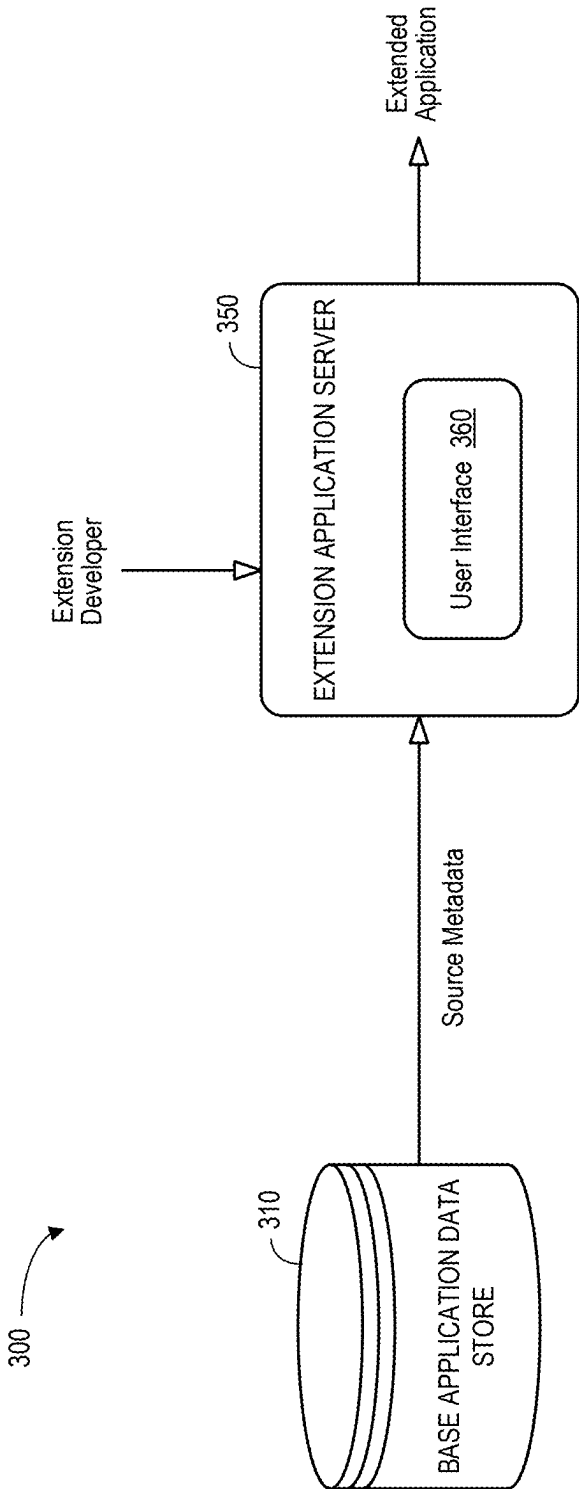


FIG. 3

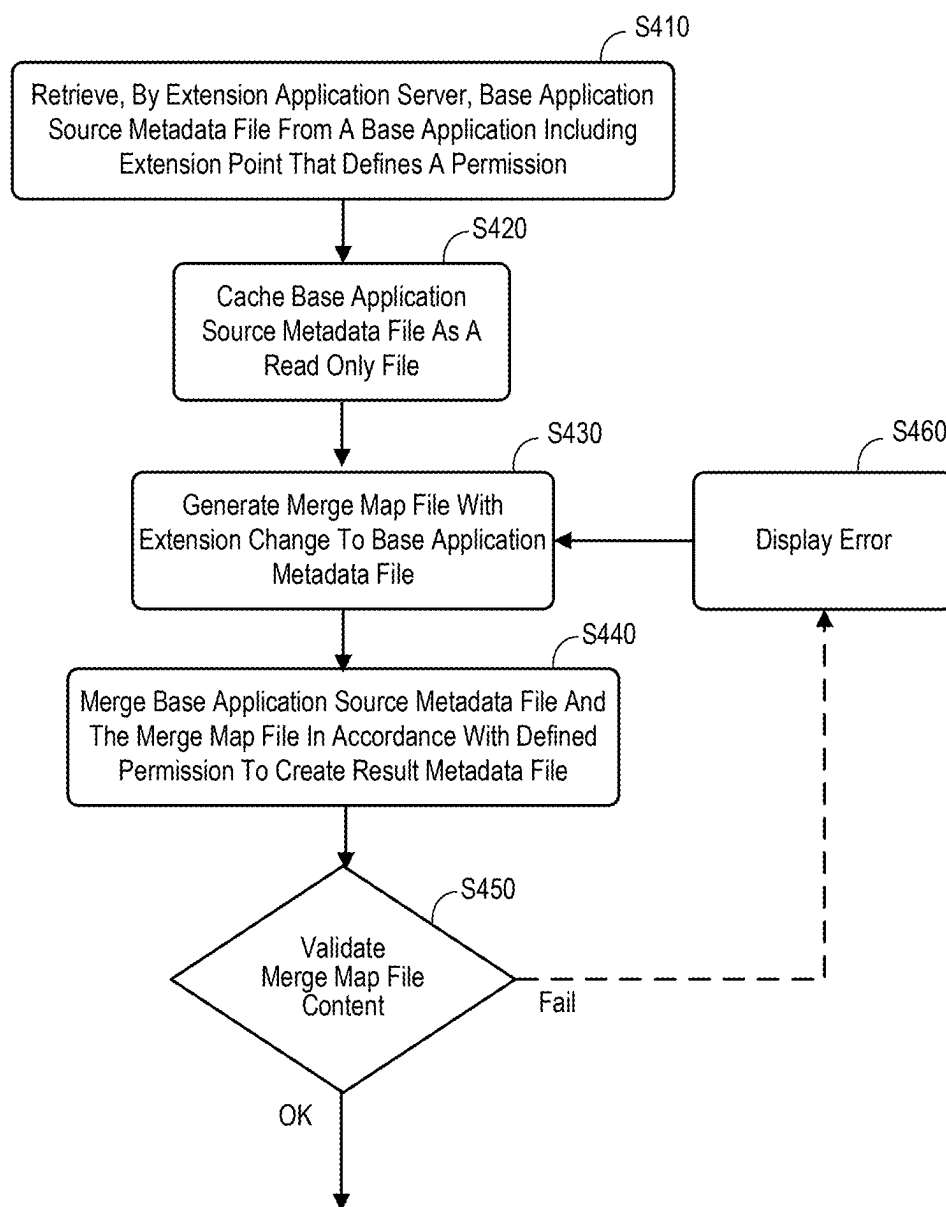


FIG. 4

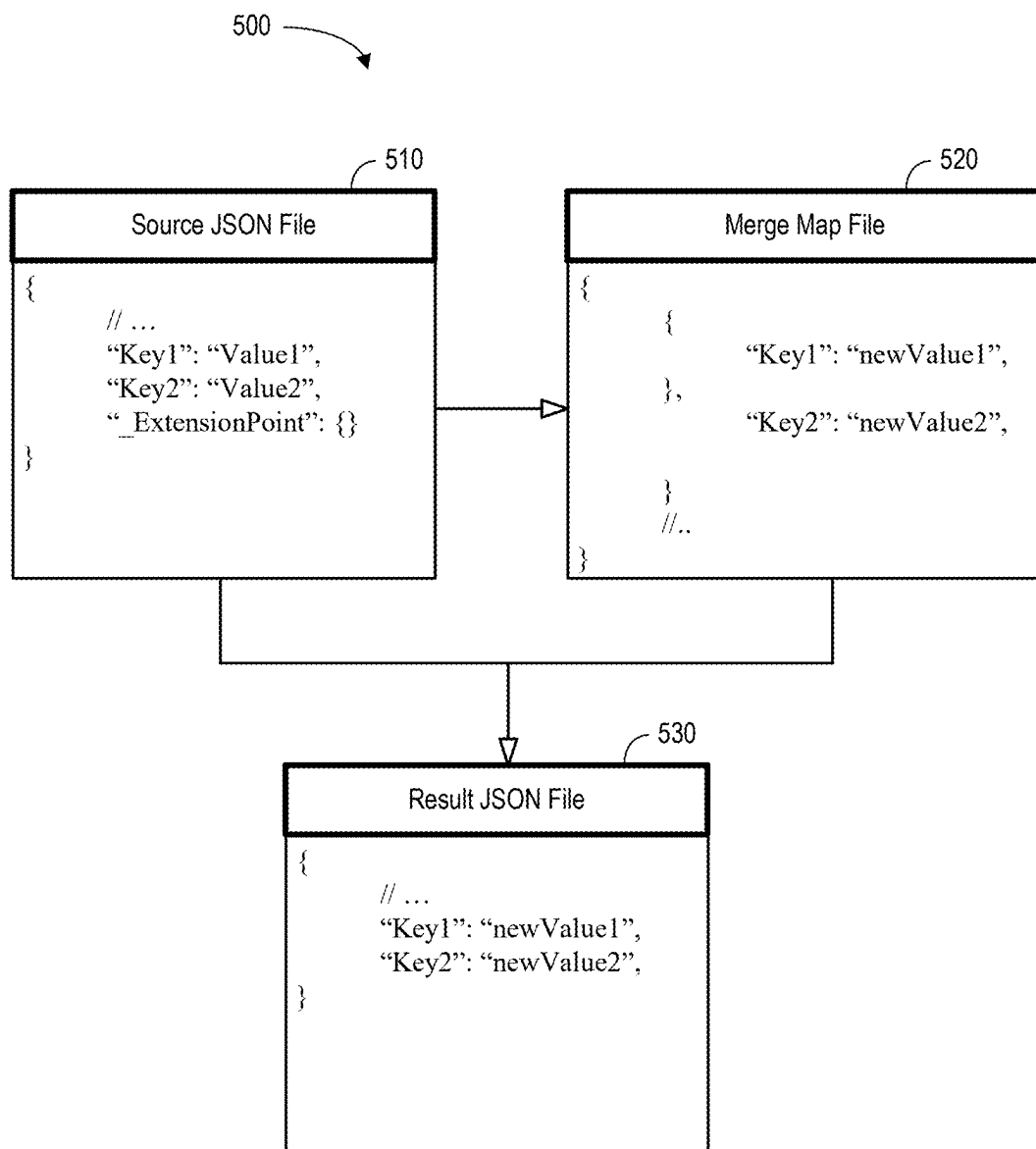


FIG. 5

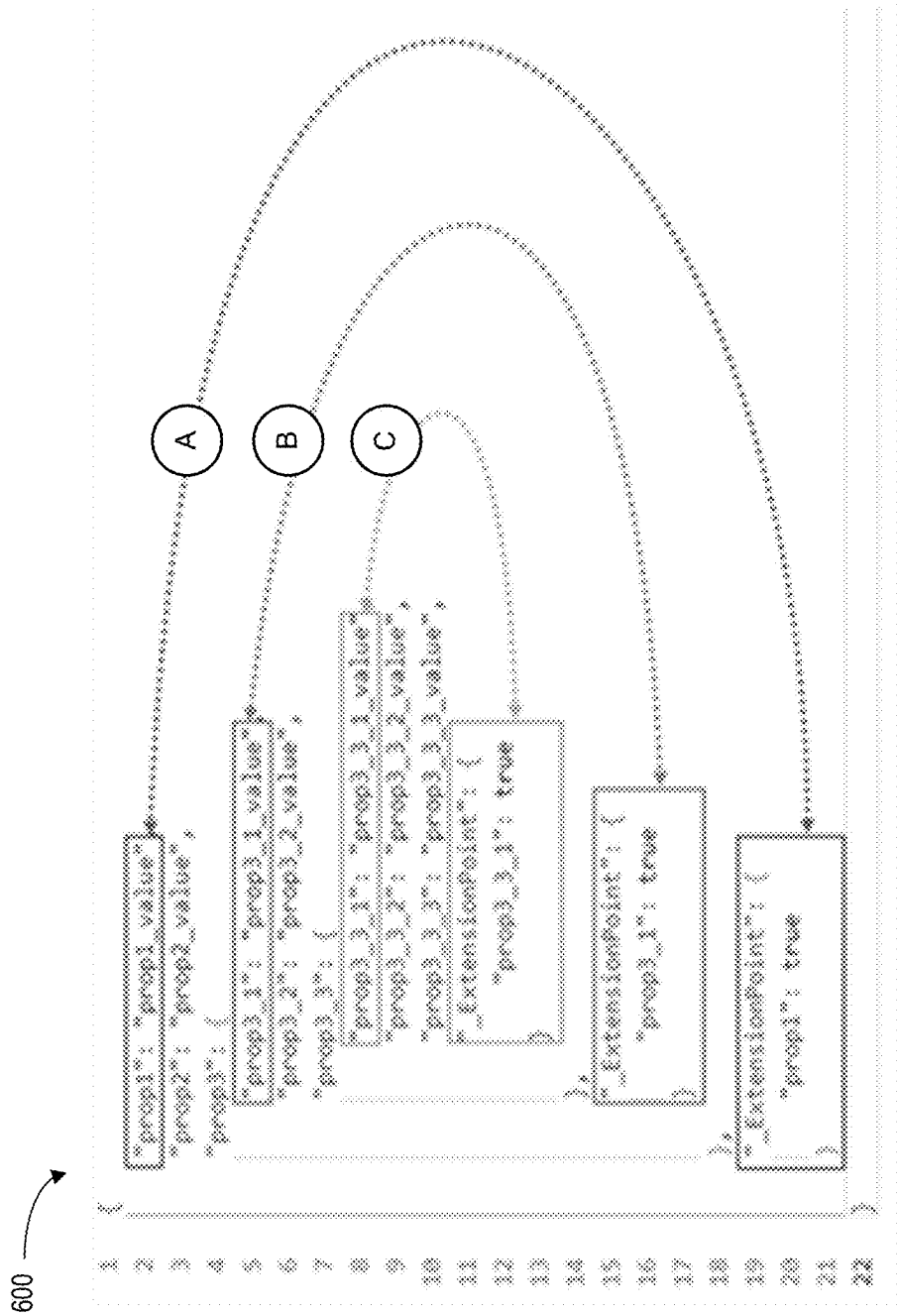


FIG. 6

700

```
1 {
2     "_Type": "Page",
3     "_Name": "Main",
4     "Caption": "Main",
5     "PrefersLargeCaption": false,
6     "_ExtensionPoint": {
7         "Caption": true,
8         "PrefersLargeCaption": true
9     }
10 }
```

710

FIG. 7

800

```
1 {  
2   "_type": "Action.Type.ODataService.UpdateEntity",  
3   "ActionResult": {  
4     "_Name": "updatesodata"  
5   },  
6   "Properties": {  
7     "City": "test city",  
8     "Country": "test country"  
9   },  
10  "_ExtensionPoint": {  
11    "Properties": {  
12      "Add",  
13      "Remove"  
14    }  
15  }  
16 }
```

810

FIG. 8

900

```
1 {
2   "_Type": "Action.Type.ODataService.UpdateEntity",
3   "ActionResult": {
4     "_Name": "updatedata"
5   },
6   "Properties": {
7     "City": "test city",
8     "Country": "test country"
9   },
10  "ExtensionPoint": {
11    "Properties": true
12  }
13 }
```

910

FIG. 9

1000

```
1 {  
2   "_type": "Section.Type.KeyValue",  
3   "_name": "WorkOrderOperationDetailSection",  
4   "KeyValueList": [  
5     {  
6       "Value": "Value",  
7       "_name": "KeyValue",  
8       "KeyName": "KeyName",  
9       "Visible": true  
10    }  
11  ]  
12  "ExtensionPoint": {  
13    "KeyValueList": [  
14      "Border",  
15      "Remove",  
16      "InsertBegin",  
17      "InsertEnd",  
18      "InsertAny"  
19    ]  
20  }  
21 }  
22 }  
23 }
```

1010

FIG. 10

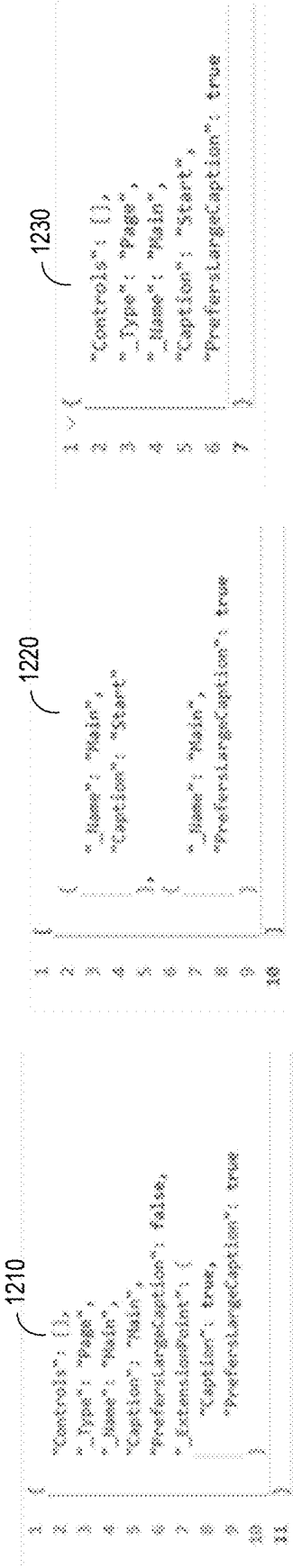
1100

```
1 {  
2   "_Type": "Section.Type.KeyValue",  
3   "_Name": "WorkOrderOperationDetailsSection",  
4   "KeyAndValues": {  
5     {  
6       "Value": "Value",  
7       "_Name": "KeyValue0",  
8       "KeyName": "KeyName",  
9       "Visible": true  
10    }  
11  }  
12  "ExtensionPoint": {  
13    "KeyAndValues": true  
14  }  
15 }
```

1110

FIG. 11

1200



Result

Main.json File in Extension Application

Main.json File in Base Application

FIG. 12

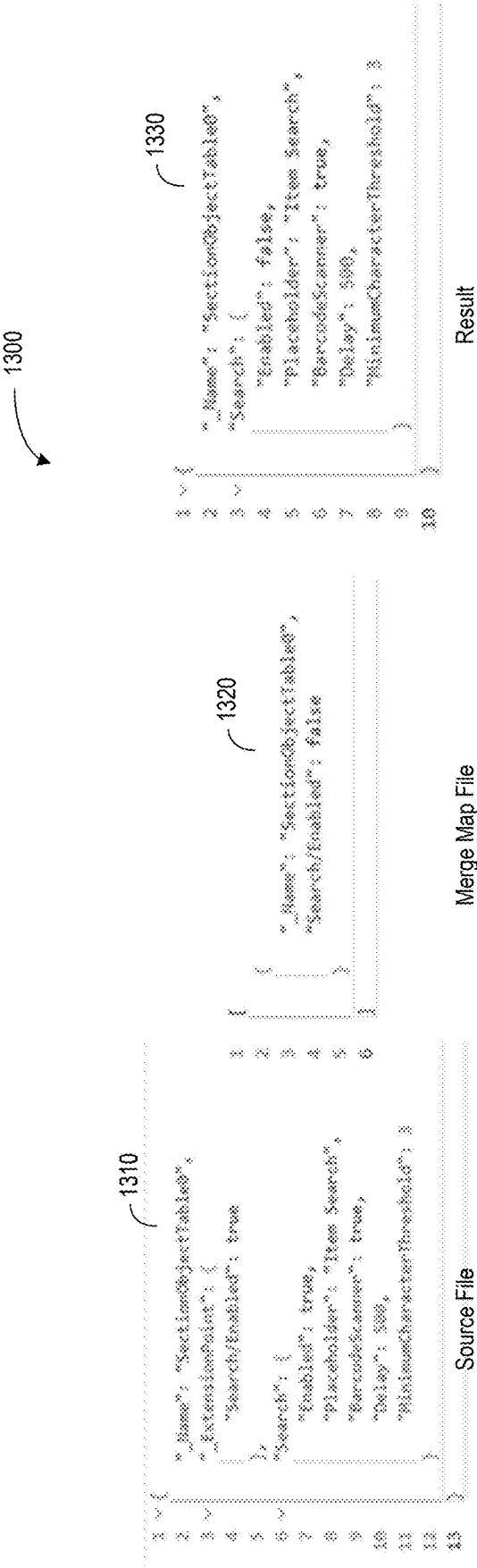


FIG. 13

1400

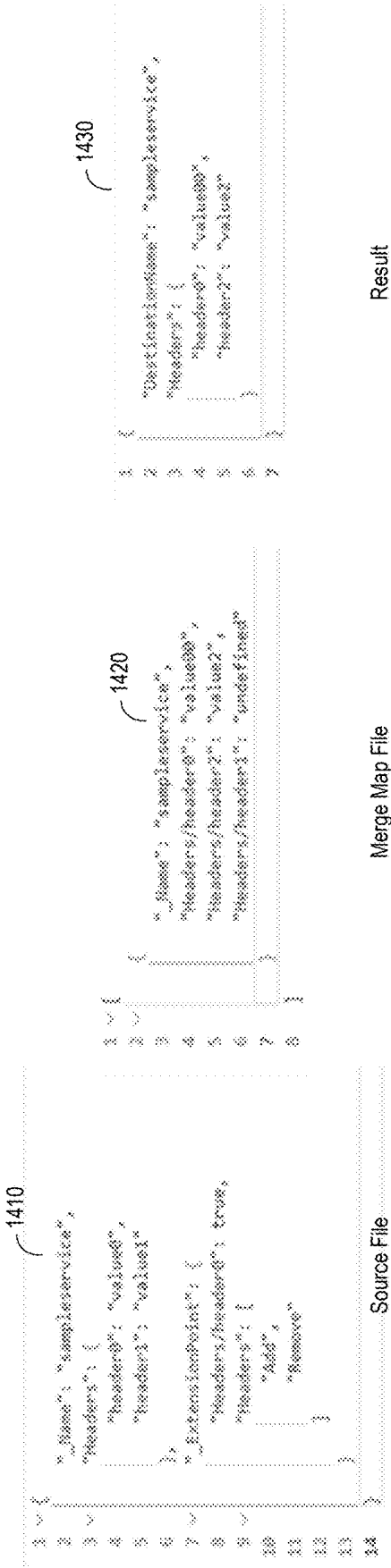


FIG. 14

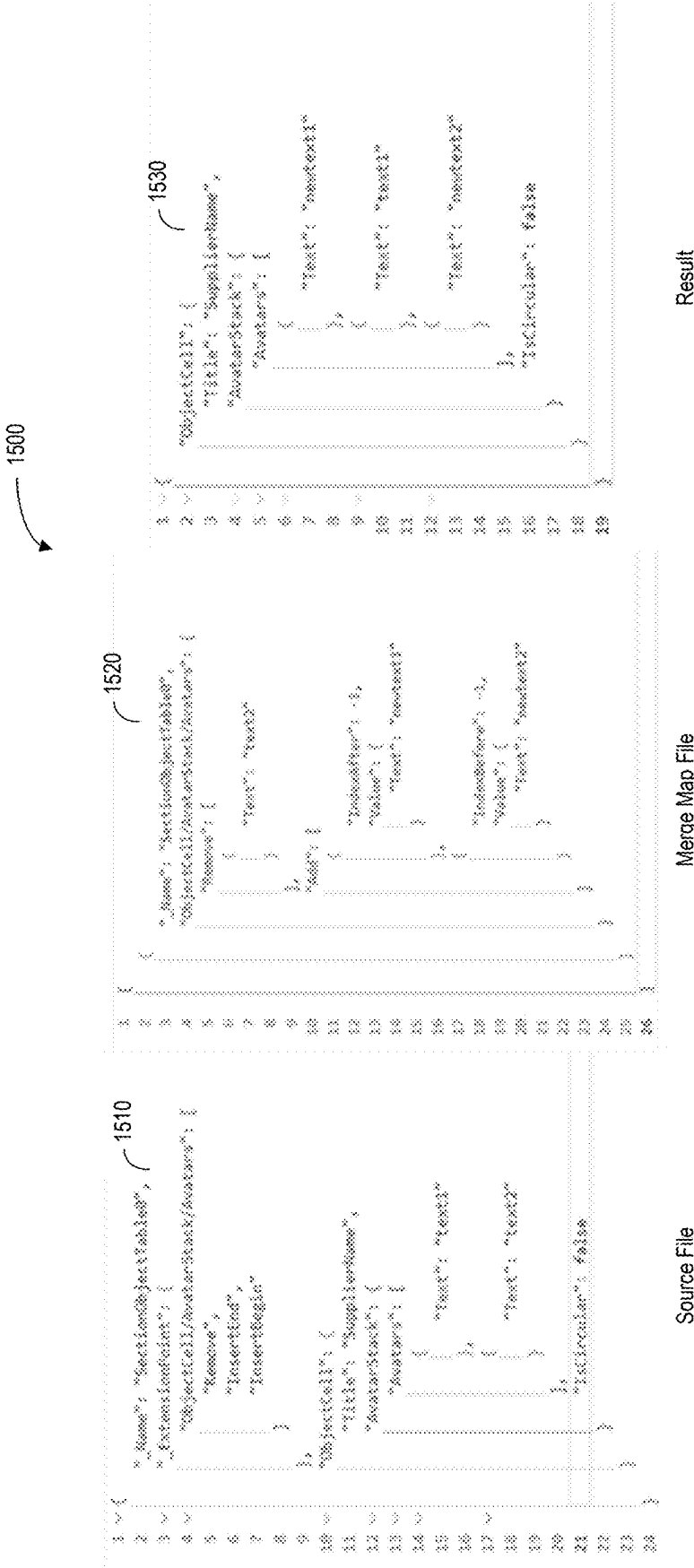
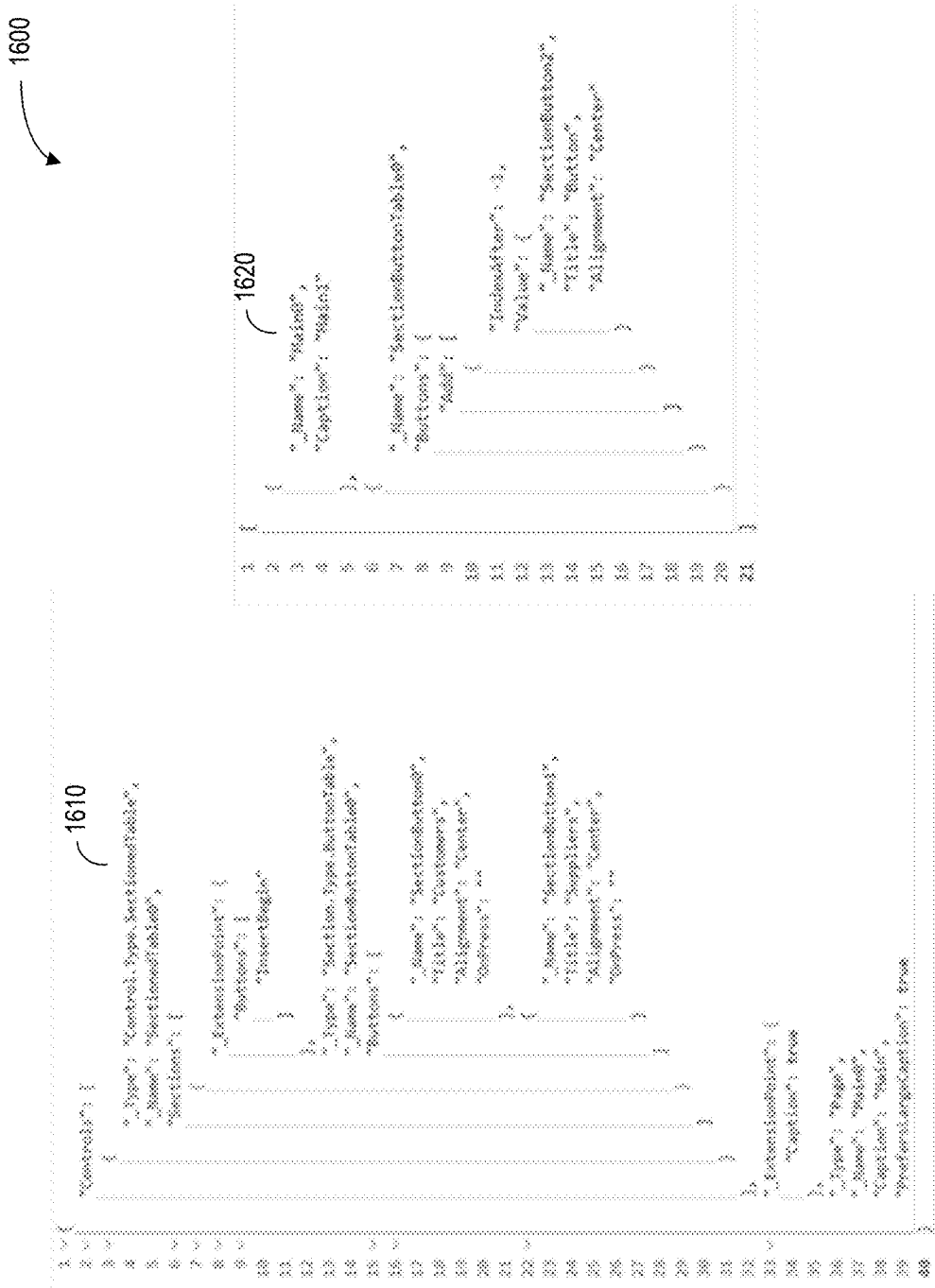


FIG. 15



Merge Map File

Source File

FIG. 16

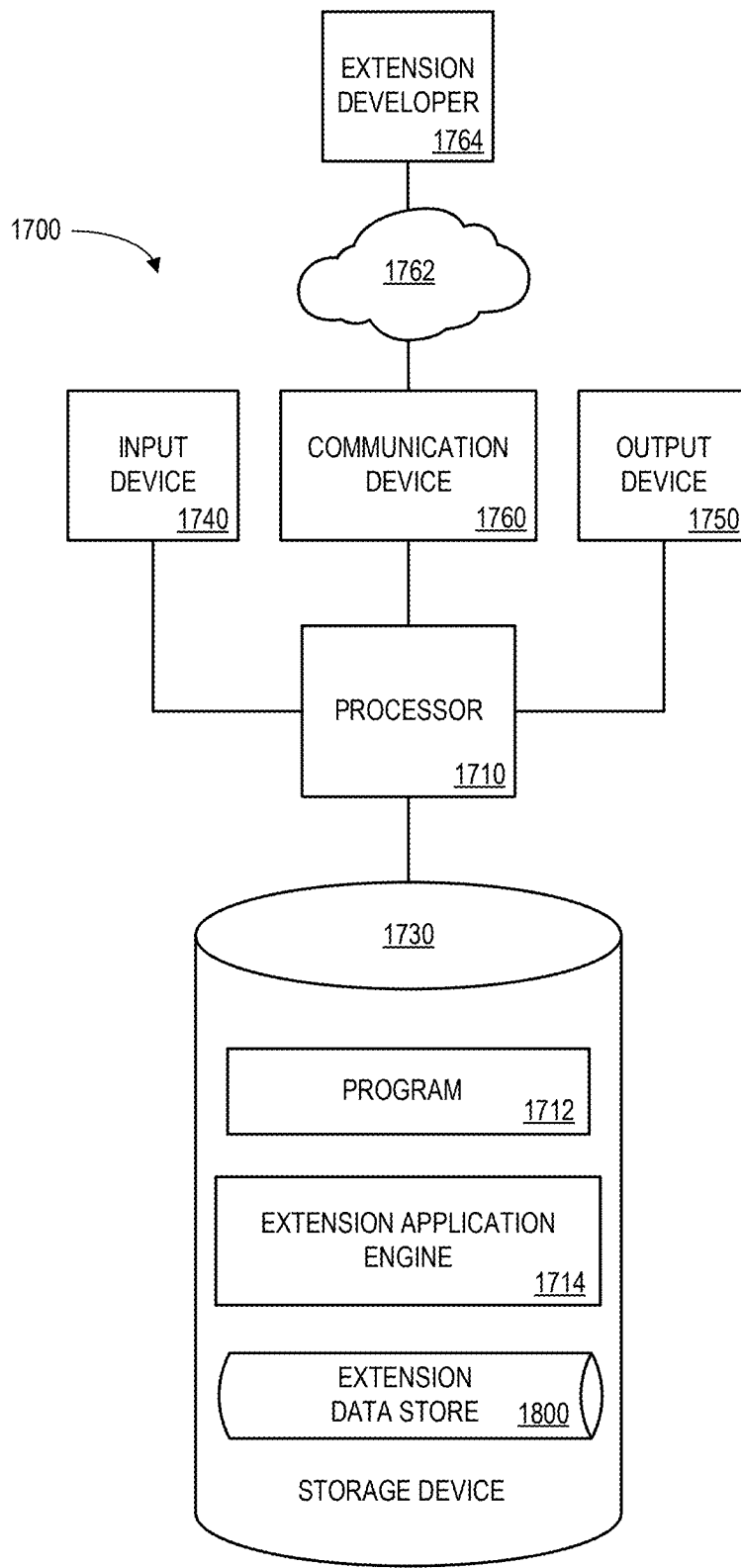


FIG. 17

1800



APPLICATION IDENTIFIER 1802	BASE METADATA FILE 1804	MERGE MAP FILE 1806	RESULT FILE 1808	VALIDATION STATUS 1810
A_101	BM_JSON_101	MM_101	R_101	VALIDATED
A_102	BM_JSON_102	MM_102	R_102	ERROR
A_103	BM_JSON_103	MM_103	R_103	VALIDATED

FIG. 18

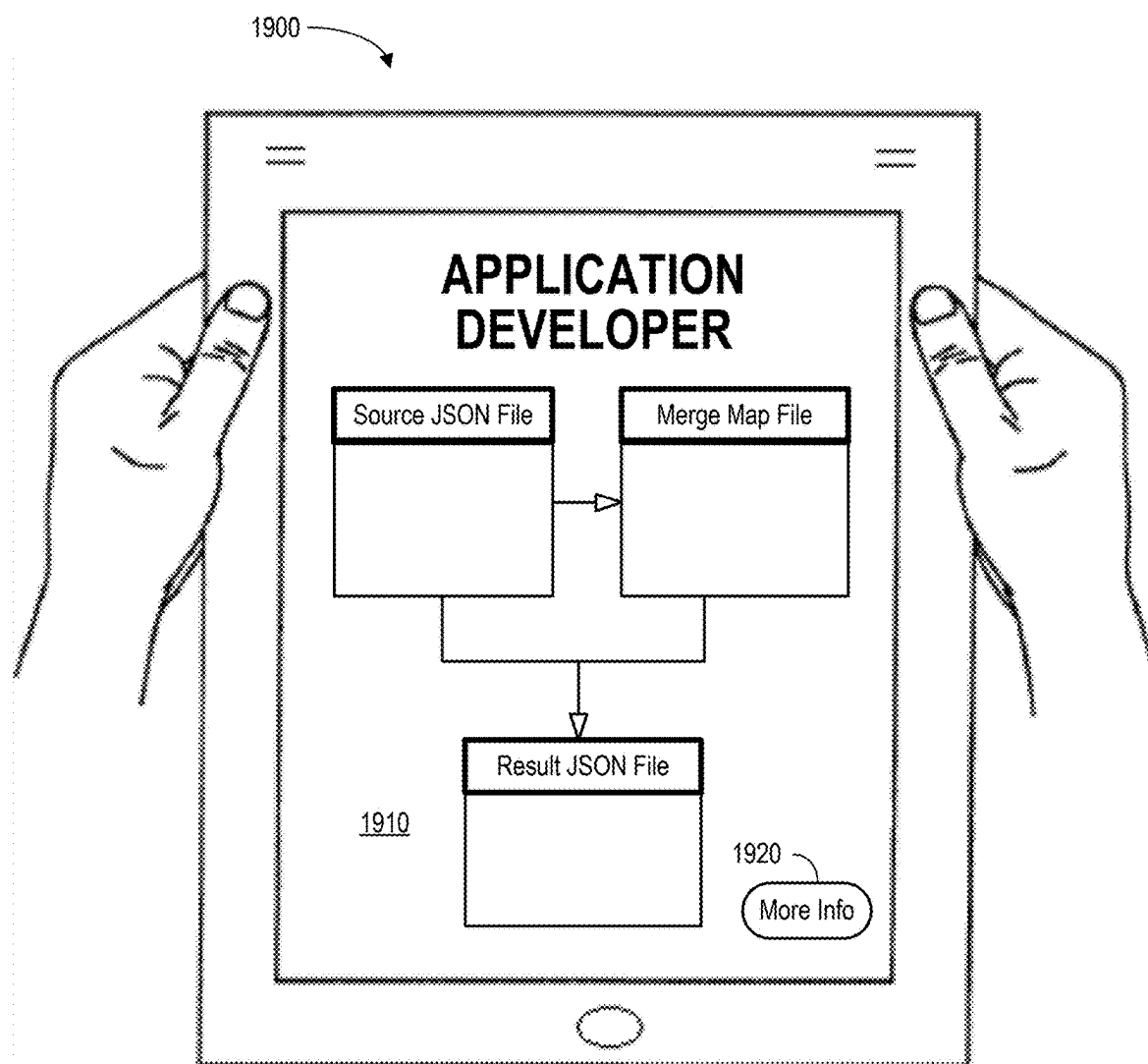


FIG. 19

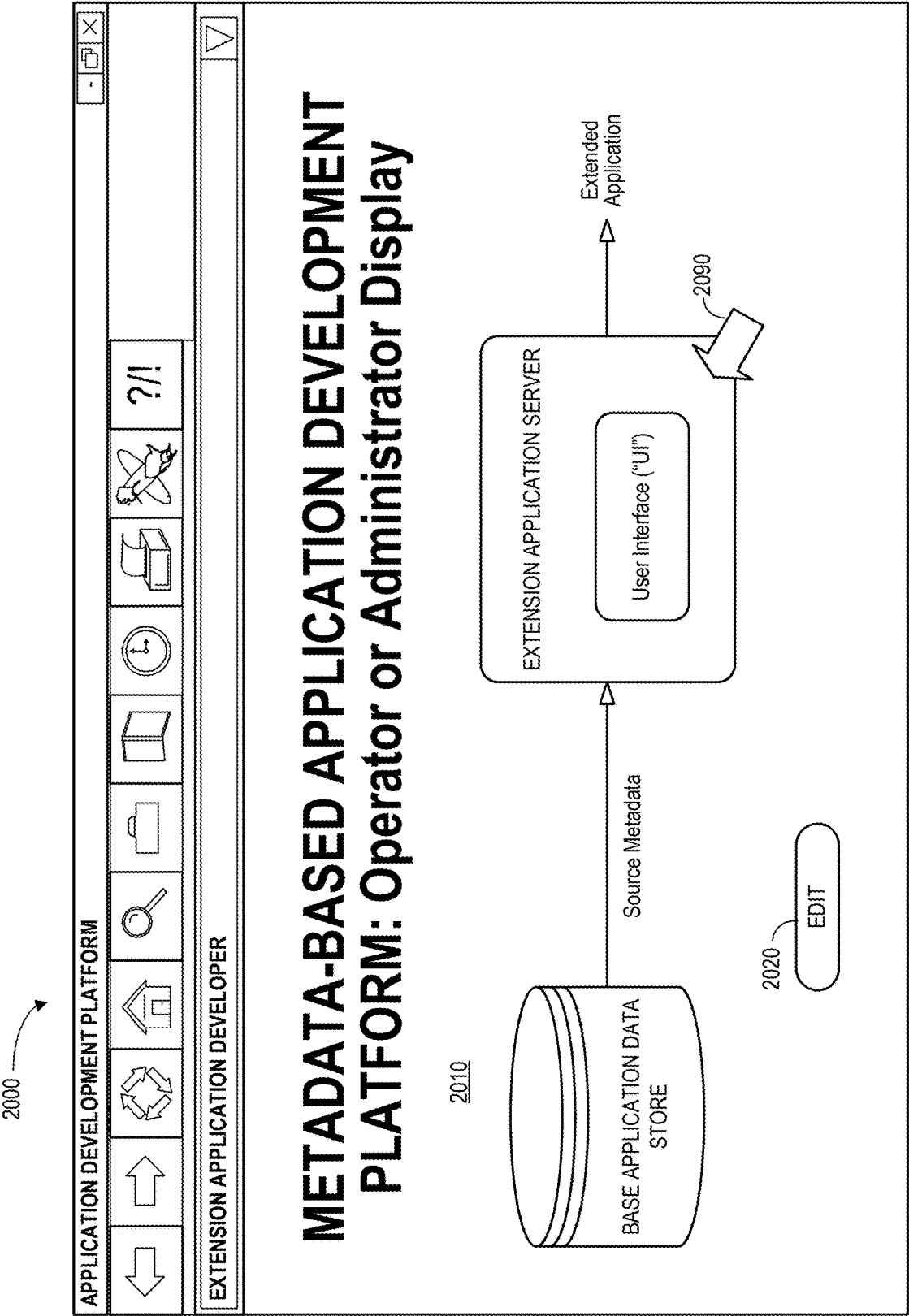


FIG. 20

METADATA DOCUMENT UPDATES FOR APPLICATION DEVELOPMENT PLATFORM

BACKGROUND

[0001] An application development platform may provide a framework that lets a developer define user applications. The platform may, for example, let the developer customize, deploy, and manage customized applications in the cloud. It may also provide native client support and consume service capabilities such as onboarding, offline Open Data Protocol (“OData”) information, life cycle management, and/or supportability. In some cases, the application development platform may be metadata-based and use, for example, a Java Script Object Notation (“JSON”) document to define metadata that lets a developer specify page, action, service, application configuration settings, etc. for an application.

[0002] In a typical framework, a base application developer may establish a base version of the application (and metadata) that may be periodically updated. An extension application developer may then make adjustments to customize the base application and create an “extended” version of the application as desired (e.g., by changing an icon label in an interface). Note, however, that some changes to the metadata might be prohibited. Moreover, manually coordinating metadata changes as they are continuously updated by both the base application developer and various extension developers can be a challenging process. It would therefore be desirable to provide improved ways for extended application updates in a secure, automatic, and efficient manner.

SUMMARY

[0003] According to some embodiments, methods and systems associated with a metadata-based application development platform may include a base application data store that contains a base application source metadata file with at least one extension point. The extension point defines a permission associated with the extension point in connection with a base application. An extension application server, coupled to the base application data store, retrieves the base application source metadata file and caches the base application source metadata file as a read only file. The extension application server then automatically generates a merge map file with an extension change to the base application metadata file. The base application source metadata file and the merge map file may be, for example, merged in accordance with the defined permission to create a result metadata file for the base application. In some embodiments, the extension application server subscribes to application updates for the base application, and the extension change is reported and validated in accordance with the permission associated with extension point.

[0004] Some embodiments comprise: means for retrieving, by a computer processor of an extension application server, a base application source metadata file from a base application data store, the base application source metadata file including at least one extension point that defines a permission associated with the at least one extension point in connection with a base application; means for caching, by the computer processor of the extension application server, the base application source metadata file as a read only file; and means for automatically generating a merge map file with an extension change to the base application metadata file, wherein the base application source metadata file and

the merge map file are merged in accordance with the defined permission to create a result metadata file for the base application.

[0005] Some technical advantages of some embodiments disclosed herein are improved systems and methods to provide extended application updates in a secure, automatic, and efficient manner.

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

[0006] FIG. 1 is a system associated with a metadata-based application development platform.

[0007] FIG. 2 is an example of a merge associated with a metadata-based application development platform extension.

[0008] FIG. 3 is a high-level architecture of a system according to some embodiments.

[0009] FIG. 4 is a method in accordance with some embodiments.

[0010] FIG. 5 is an example of an automatic extension merge according to some embodiments.

[0011] FIG. 6 is an example including multiple extension points in accordance with some embodiments.

[0012] FIG. 7 is a file with an extension point setting for a simple property according to some embodiments.

[0013] FIG. 8 is a file with an add or remove extension point setting for an object property in accordance with some embodiments.

[0014] FIG. 9 is a file with an override extension point setting for an object property according to some embodiments.

[0015] FIG. 10 is a file with a re-order, remove, or insert extension point setting for an array property in accordance with some embodiments.

[0016] FIG. 11 is an override extension point setting for an array property according to some embodiments.

[0017] FIG. 12 is an example in accordance with some embodiments.

[0018] FIG. 13 is an example where only a “Search.Enabled” property can be changed according to some embodiments.

[0019] FIG. 14 is an example where only a “Headers” object property is allowed to add or remove properties in accordance with some embodiments.

[0020] FIG. 15 is an example of an array type property according to some embodiments.

[0021] FIG. 16 is an example of a “_Name” property in a merge map file in accordance with some embodiments.

[0022] FIG. 17 is an apparatus or platform according to some embodiments.

[0023] FIG. 18 is a portion of an extension data store in accordance with some embodiments.

[0024] FIG. 19 illustrates a tablet computer according to some embodiments.

[0025] FIG. 20 is an operator or administrator display in accordance with some embodiments.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

[0026] In the following detailed description, numerous specific details are set forth in order to provide a thorough understanding of embodiments. However, it will be understood by those of ordinary skill in the art that the embodiments may be practiced without these specific details. In

other instances, well-known methods, procedures, components and circuits have not been described in detail so as not to obscure the embodiments.

[0027] One or more specific embodiments of the present invention will be described below. In an effort to provide a concise description of these embodiments, all features of an actual implementation may not be described in the specification. It should be appreciated that in the development of any such actual implementation, as in any engineering or design project, numerous implementation-specific decisions must be made to achieve the developers' specific goals, such as compliance with system-related and business-related constraints, which may vary from one implementation to another. Moreover, it should be appreciated that such a development effort might be complex and time consuming, but would nevertheless be a routine undertaking of design, fabrication, and manufacture for those of ordinary skill having the benefit of this disclosure.

[0028] An application development platform may provide a framework that lets a developer define user applications. For example, the Mobile Development Kit ("MDK") for SAP™ Mobile Services is a metadata-based application development platform that lets developer customize, deploy, and manage customized iOS and Android applications in the cloud. It also provides native client support and consumes mobile services capabilities such as onboarding, offline OData, life cycle management, and supportability through the SAP™ Business Technology Platform using a MDK client. FIG. 1 is a system 100 associated with a metadata-based application development platform. The system 100 includes a base application 110 that can be used to create an extended application 120. The system 100 lets a base application developer generate metadata and JavaScript (in an editor) which is translated to native code at runtime and deployed to a native applications on devices. The same metadata can also be deployed to the web to run the same application in a browser. Reusable components are stand-alone applications that can include pages, actions, rules and global variables. As stand-alone applications, they can be built, tested, and updated separately from the base application 110 to customize, add-on, and/or extend existing applications without modifying the base application 110. The extended application 120 may subscribe to the base application 110 such that any application update 112 to the base application 110 can be applied to the extended application 120 as an application update 122.

[0029] Differences in the metadata between the base application 110 and the extended application 120 may need to be merged. For example, a customer may like to extend an existing MDK application with released metadata, and to customize it for further development. When the base metadata changes, the extended application can get the updates and merge the difference automatically without any manual changes in accordance with some embodiments. FIG. 2 is an example 200 of a merge associated with a metadata-based application development platform extension. A base application includes a main.json file (version one) 210. An extension application developer wants to extend the base application and customize it. As a result, in the extension application the main.json file 220 changes the property "Caption" value from "Main" to "Start." Then, the base application is updated and in the main.json file (version two) 230 the property "PrefersLargeCaption" value is changed from "true" to "false." Finally, in the extension application

the result main.json 240 should reflect merged content from those two files 220, 230 (with property "Caption" equaling "Start" and property "PrefersLargeCaption" equaling "false.")

[0030] FIG. 3 is a high-level block diagram of one example of a system 300 associated with application development in which a base application data store 310 may exchange information with an extension application server 350. In particular, the extension application server 350 may receive source metadata from the base application data store 310. The source metadata may be associated with, for example, a base application.

[0031] As used herein, devices, including those associated with the system 300 and any other device described herein, may exchange information via any communication network which may be one or more of a Local Area Network ("LAN"), a Metropolitan Area Network ("MAN"), a Wide Area Network ("WAN"), a proprietary network, a Public Switched Telephone Network ("PSTN"), a Wireless Application Protocol ("WAP") network, a Bluetooth network, a wireless LAN network, and/or an Internet Protocol ("IP") network such as the Internet, an intranet, or an extranet. Note that any devices described herein may communicate via one or more such communication networks.

[0032] The extension application server 350 may store information into and/or retrieve information from various data stores (e.g., the base application data store 310), which may be locally stored or reside remote from the extension application server 350. Although a single extension application server 350 is shown in FIG. 3, any number of such devices may be included. Moreover, various devices described herein might be combined according to embodiments of the present invention. The system 300 functions may be performed by a constellation of networked apparatuses, such as in a distributed processing or cloud-based architecture.

[0033] An operator or administrator may access the system 300 via a remote device (e.g., a Personal Computer ("PC"), tablet, or smartphone) to view information about and/or manage operational information in accordance with any of the embodiments described herein. In some cases, a User Interface ("UI") 360 may let an operator, administrator, or extension developer define and/or adjust certain parameters via a remote device (e.g., to specify metadata adjustments for an extended application) and/or provide or receive automatically generated recommendations, alerts, or results associated with the system 300.

[0034] FIG. 4 is a method according to some embodiments. The flow charts described herein do not imply a fixed order to the steps, and embodiments of the present invention may be practiced in any order that is practicable. Note that any of the methods described herein may be performed by hardware, software, an automated script of commands, or any combination of these approaches. For example, a computer-readable storage medium may store thereon instructions that when executed by a machine result in performance according to any of the embodiments described herein.

[0035] At S410, a computer processor of an extension application server may retrieve a base application source metadata file from a base application data store. The base application source metadata file may include at least one extension point that defines a permission associated with the extension point in connection with a base application. According to some embodiments, the extension application

server subscribes to application updates for the base application. At **S420**, the computer processor of the extension application server may cache the base application source metadata file as a read only file. According to some embodiments, the base application source metadata file includes a plurality of extension points that each define at least one permission in connection with the base application.

[0036] At **S430**, the system may automatically generate a merge map file with an extension change to the base application metadata file (e.g., in accordance with information received from an extension developer). At **S440**, the base application source metadata file and the merge map file may be merged in accordance with the defined permission to create a result metadata file for the base application. In some embodiments, the extension point and permission are associated with a simple property and comprise an indication of which properties are allowed to be extended. As another example, the extension point and permission may be associated with an object property and comprise an ability to add, remove, and/or override an object property. As still another example, the extension point and permission might be associated with an array property and an ability to reorder, remove, and/or insert information in an array.

[0037] According to some embodiments, the extension change is reported and validated in accordance with the permission associated with the extension point. If the extension change is OK at **S450**, the process is complete. If the extension change fails validation at **S450**, and error is displayed at **S460**. For example, the error might be displayed to an extension developer in substantially real time when the extension change is incompatible with the permission (so that the process can continue at **S430** to let the extension developer make a correction). In some embodiments, an error summary project report table may be provided to a base developer for extension changes that were incompatible with the permission.

[0038] FIG. 5 is an example **500** of an automatic extension merge according to some embodiments. In a source or base JSON file **510**, extension points are defined in the base application for any files that we want to let an extension application change. The extension application caches the whole base application content as a read only file. If the developer wants to change the file, any content coming from the base application automatically generates a new merge map **520** that includes all of the changes. When the base application is updated, all updates are synchronized to the cached content in the extension application. A result JSON file **530** is merged from the latest source file from the base application and the merge map file that was generated by the extension application.

[0039] In any JSON document that defines extension points, one or more “_ExtensionPoint” properties can be added at the same level of the property that will allow changes. FIG. 6 is an example JSON document **600** that includes multiple extension points in accordance with some embodiments. A section (A) is setting an extension point for a first level property “prop1”, a section (B) is setting an extension point for a second level property “prop3_1”, and a section (C) is setting an extension point for a third level property “prop3_3_1”, etc.

[0040] According to some embodiments, an extension point may be associated with a simple property. This may be applicable, for example, in connection with property types of Boolean, string, and/or number. It may use a Boolean

value to indicate which properties can be extended. FIG. 7 is a file with an extension point setting for a simple property **700** according to some embodiments. Here, only the property “Caption” and “PrefersLargeCaption” values are allowed to be changed **710** in an extension application (and other properties cannot be changed).

[0041] According to some embodiments, an extension point may be associated with an object type property. For example, an add and/or remove extension point may allow for adding new properties to an object or removing existing properties from an object. FIG. 8 is a file with an add or remove extension point setting for an object property **800** in accordance with some embodiments. Here, only “Properties” is allowed to add new properties or remove existing properties **810** in the extension application. As another example, an override extension point may apply to the whole object property. FIG. 9 is a file with an override extension point setting for an object property **900** according to some embodiments. Here, the “Properties” is allowed to be changed to any other value in the extension application **910**, such as a string or a number.

[0042] According to some embodiments, an extension point may be associated with an array property. According to some embodiments, such an extension point supports three different definitions: (1) reorder, (2) remove, and (3) insert. Reorder and remove may allow reordering or removing items for an array property and insert may allow for the insertion of one or more items at a specified position into the current array property. There are three positions are supported:

[0043] InsertBegin: at the beginning position,

[0044] InsertEnd: at the ending position, and

[0045] InsertAny: at the any position.

FIG. 10 is a file with a re-order, remove, or insert extension point setting for an array property **1000** in accordance with some embodiments. Here, the property “KeyAndValues” value is allowed to reorder, remove, or insert new items to any position of the “KeyAndValues” array in the extension application **1010**. As with the object type property, embodiments may also override the whole array property. FIG. 11 is an override extension point setting for an array property **1100** (applying to “KeyAndValues” **1110**) according to some embodiments.

[0046] In an extension application, the whole base application content will be cached as a read only file. If needed, a developer can synchronize it from the base application to get updates at any time. When the JSON file content is changed, a new merge map file will be generated automatically with the same name as the original JSON file. All of the changed content will be contained in the merge map file. FIG. 12 is an example **1200** in accordance with some embodiments.

[0047] A main.json file in a base application **1210** includes extension points and is cached in an extension application. When the file content is updated, the main.json file **1210** will not be changed. Instead, a new main.merge map file will be generated as shown by the main.json file in extension application **1220**. This can then be used to create the result **1230**.

[0048] In the merge map file, the content may always be treated as an array and each item may comprise a changing point based on the extension point setting in the source JSON file of the base application. Here, the property “_Name” is required and the value must be unique in the

source JSON document. Subsequently, the automatic merging process will use it to locate the position in the source JSON document.

[0049] This example **1200** is related to one of the different extension point settings (which is the easiest scenario). FIG. **13** is another possible example **1300** of a source file **1310**, a merge map file **1320**, and a result **1330** where only a “Search.Enabled” property can be changed according to some embodiments. FIG. **14** is still another example **1400** of a source file **1410**, a merge map file **1420**, and a result **1430** where only a “Headers” object property is allowed to add or remove properties in accordance with some embodiments. In particular, the property “Headers/header0” is allowed to be changed as “value00” because in source file there is a setting “Headers/header0”: true in the “_ExtensionPoint” section. Besides that, in merge map file “Headers/header1”: “undefined” means that the property “Headers.header1” will be removed during the merging process, and “Headers/header2”: “value2” is a newly added item.

[0050] FIG. **15** is an example **1500** of a source file **1510**, a merge map file **1520**, and a result **1530** associated with an array type property according to some embodiments. The example **1500** removes “text2” and adds two new items “newtext1” and “newtext2.” The keyword “IndexAfter” means starting from the beginning of the array items, and the keyword “IndexBefore” means starting from the ending of the array items (they both may, for example, count from -1). The merge map file **1520** is generated based on the “_ExtensionPoint” definition in the source JSON file **1510**, and result **1530** content in the final JSON file is merged from the source JSON file **1510** and merge map file **1520**.

[0051] FIG. **16** is an example **1600** of a “_Name” property in a source file **1610** a merge map file **1620** in accordance with some embodiments. Note that the “_Name” property may not be required in the merge map file **1620** unless there are multiple “_ExtensionPoint” definitions in the source JSON file **1610**. Considering the example **1600** of FIG. **16**, there are two “_ExtensionPoint” definitions, so the generated merge map file **1620** uses “_Name” property to distinguish each changing point.

[0052] Note that the embodiments described herein may be implemented using any number of different hardware configurations. For example, FIG. **17** is a block diagram of an apparatus or platform **1700** that may be, for example, associated with the system **300** of FIG. **3** (and/or any other system described herein). The platform **1700** comprises a processor **1710**, such as one or more commercially available Central Processing Units (“CPUs”) in the form of one-chip microprocessors, coupled to a communication device **1760** configured to communicate via a communication network **1762**. The communication device **1760** may be used to communicate, for example, with one or more remote extension developers **1764**, administrator platforms, etc. The platform **1700** further includes an input device **1740** (e.g., a computer mouse and/or keyboard to input mappings and/or merging information) and/or an output device **1750** (e.g., a computer monitor to render a display, transmit recommendations and alerts, and/or create reports about mergers, extensions, tenants, etc.).

[0053] The processor **1710** also communicates with a storage device **1730**. The storage device **1730** may comprise any appropriate information storage device, including combinations of magnetic storage devices (e.g., a hard disk drive), optical storage devices, mobile telephones, and/or

semiconductor memory devices. The storage device **1730** stores a program **1712** and/or extension application engine **1714** for controlling the processor **1710**. The processor **1710** performs instructions of the programs **1712**, **1714**, and thereby operates in accordance with any of the embodiments described herein. For example, the processor **1710** may retrieve a base application source metadata file and cache the base application source metadata file as a read only file. The processor **1710** may then generate a merge map file with an extension change to the base application metadata file. The base application source metadata file and the merge map file may be, for example, merged in accordance with the defined permission to create a result metadata file for the base application. In some embodiments, the extension application server subscribes to application updates for the base application, and the extension change is reported and validated in accordance with the permission associated with extension point.

[0054] The programs **1712**, **1714** may be stored in a compressed, uncompiled and/or encrypted format. The programs **1712**, **1714** may furthermore include other program elements, such as an operating system, clipboard application, a database management system, and/or device drivers used by the processor **1710** to interface with peripheral devices.

[0055] As used herein, information may be “received” by or “transmitted” to, for example: (i) the platform **1700** from another device; or (ii) a software application or module within the platform **1700** from another software application, module, or any other source.

[0056] In some embodiments (such as the one shown in FIG. **17**), the storage device **1730** further stores an extension data store **1800**. An example of a database that may be used in connection with the platform **1700** will now be described in detail with respect to FIG. **18**. Note that the database described herein is only one example, and additional and/or different information may be stored therein. Moreover, various databases might be split or combined in accordance with any of the embodiments described herein.

[0057] Referring to FIG. **18**, a table is shown that represents the extension data store **1800** that may be stored at the platform **1700** according to some embodiments. The table may include, for example, entries identifying applications and/or extensions associated with a metadata-based application development platform. The table may also define fields **1802**, **1804**, **1806**, **1808**, **1810** for each of the entries. The fields **1802**, **1804**, **1806**, **1808**, **1810** may, according to some embodiments, specify: an application identifier **1802**, a base metadata file **1804**, a merge map file **1806**, a result file **1808**, and a validation status **1810**. The extension data store **1800** may be created and updated, for example, when a base application is added or updated, an extension is created, etc.

[0058] The application identifier **1802** might be a unique alphanumeric label that is associated with a particular base application of the application development platform. The base metadata file **1804** may represent the JSON file that includes allowed extension permissions. The merge map file **1806** may be used to incorporate updates and/or changes creating the result file **1808**. The validation status **1810** might indicate, for example, that an extension has been verified as allowed or an error indicates that a correction needs to be made to comply with extension point permissions.

[0059] In this way, embodiments may avoid manual merges of differences during synchronous updates from a base application into an extension application. When the developer changes files in the extension application, the updates are not reflected in the source file and are instead stored in a merge map file based on the extension point definitions in the source file. If the base application has the updates for a new version, the extension application can easily merge the content with simple logic.

[0060] The following illustrates various additional embodiments of the invention. These do not constitute a definition of all possible embodiments, and those skilled in the art will understand that the present invention is applicable to many other embodiments. Further, although the following embodiments are briefly described for clarity, those skilled in the art will understand how to make any changes, if necessary, to the above-described apparatus and methods to accommodate these and other embodiments and applications.

[0061] Although specific hardware and data configurations have been described herein, note that any number of other configurations may be provided in accordance with some embodiments of the present invention (e.g., some of the information associated with the databases described herein may be combined or stored in external systems). Moreover, although some embodiments are focused on particular types of applications and extensions, any of the embodiments described herein could be applied to other types of applications and extensions. Moreover, the displays shown herein are provided only as examples, and any other type of user interface could be implemented. For example, FIG. 19 illustrates a tablet computer 1900 providing an application developer display 1910. The display 1910 might be used, for example, to modify aspects of a metadata document framework, an extension, etc. via selection of a “More Info” icon 1920.

[0062] FIG. 20 is an operator or administrator display in accordance with some embodiments. The display 2000 includes a graphical representation 2010 of a metadata document update framework in accordance with any of the embodiments described herein. Selection of an element on the display 2000 (e.g., via a touchscreen or computer pointer 2090) may result in display of a pop-up window containing more detailed information about that element and/or various options (e.g., mapping options, extensions, error alerts, etc.). Selection of an “Edit” icon 2020 may also let an operator or administrator adjust the operation of the system (e.g., to change system mappings, adjust a base application data store, etc.).

[0063] The present invention has been described in terms of several embodiments solely for the purpose of illustration. Persons skilled in the art will recognize from this description that the invention is not limited to the embodiments described but may be practiced with modifications and alterations limited only by the spirit and scope of the appended claims.

1. A system associated with a metadata-based application development platform, comprising:

a base application data store containing a base application source metadata file with at least one extension point that defines a permission associated with the at least one extension point in connection with a base application; and

an extension application server, coupled to the base application data store, including:

a computer processor; and

a computer memory storing instructions that, when executed by the computer processor, cause the extension application to:

retrieve the base application source metadata file,

cache the base application source metadata file as a read only file, and

automatically generate a merge map file with an extension change to the base application metadata file,

wherein the base application source metadata file and the merge map file are merged in accordance with the defined permission to create a result metadata file for the base application.

2. The system of claim 1, wherein the extension application server subscribes to application updates for the base application.

3. The system of claim 2, wherein the extension change is reported and validated in accordance with the permission associated with the at least one extension point.

4. The system of claim 3, wherein an error is displayed to an extension developer in substantially real time when the extension change is incompatible with the permission.

5. The system of claim 3, wherein an error summary project report table is provided to a base developer for extension changes that were incompatible with the permission.

6. The system of claim 1, wherein the at least one extension point and permission are associated with a simple property and comprise an indication of which properties are allowed to be extended.

7. The system of claim 1, wherein the at least one extension point and permission are associated with an object property and comprise an ability to add, remove, or override an object property.

8. The system of claim 1, wherein the at least one extension point and permission are associated with an array property and an ability to reorder, remove, or insert information in an array.

9. The system of claim 1, wherein the base application source metadata file includes a plurality of extension points that each define at least one permission in connection with the base application.

10. A computer-implemented method associated with a metadata-based application development platform, comprising:

retrieving, by a computer processor of an extension application server, a base application source metadata file from a base application data store, the base application source metadata file including at least one extension point that defines a permission associated with the at least one extension point in connection with a base application;

caching, by the computer processor of the extension application server, the base application source metadata file as a read only file; and

automatically generating a merge map file with an extension change to the base application metadata file,

wherein the base application source metadata file and the merge map file are merged in accordance with the defined permission to create a result metadata file for the base application.

11. The method of claim **10**, wherein the extension application server subscribes to application updates for the base application.

12. The method of claim **11**, wherein the extension change is reported and validated in accordance with the permission associated with the at least one extension point.

13. The method of claim **12**, wherein an error is displayed to an extension developer in substantially real time when the extension change is incompatible with the permission.

14. The method of claim **12**, wherein an error summary project report table is provided to a base developer for extension changes that were incompatible with the permission.

15. The method of claim **10**, wherein the at least one extension point and permission are associated with a simple property and comprise an indication of which properties are allowed to be extended.

16. The method of claim **10**, wherein the at least one extension point and permission are associated with an object property and comprise an ability to add, remove, or override an object property.

17. The method of claim **10**, wherein the at least one extension point and permission are associated with an array property and an ability to reorder, remove, or insert information in an array.

18. The method of claim **10**, wherein the base application source metadata file includes a plurality of extension points that each define at least one permission in connection with the base application.

19. A non-transitory, machine-readable medium comprising instructions thereon that, when executed by a processor,

cause the processor to execute operations to perform a method associated with a metadata-based application development platform, the method comprising:

retrieving, by a computer processor of an extension application server, a base application source metadata file from a base application data store, the base application source metadata file including at least one extension point that defines a permission associated with the at least one extension point in connection with a base application;

caching, by the computer processor of the extension application server, the base application source metadata file as a read only file; and

automatically generating a merge map file with an extension change to the base application metadata file,

wherein the base application source metadata file and the merge map file are merged in accordance with the defined permission to create a result metadata file for the base application.

20. The medium of claim **19**, wherein: (i) the extension application server subscribes to application updates for the base application, and (ii) the extension change is reported and validated in accordance with the permission associated with the at least one extension point.

21. The medium of claim **20**, wherein: (i) an error is displayed to an extension developer in substantially real time when the extension change is incompatible with the permission, and (ii) an error summary project report table is provided to a base developer for extension changes that were incompatible with the permission.

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